

Course Schedule

Week 1 (January 12, 2026)

Module 1

Introduction to Local Government

Topics

- Structure of government in Canada
- What is local government?
- Why do we need to study local government?

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, students should be able to:

- Describe the structure of government in Canada
- Identify key characteristics of local government
- Explain why local government is important to study
- Distinguish responsibilities of each level/form of government, with a focus on municipal responsibilities

Readings

Required Readings

1. Tindal, C. (2005). What are our many governments and what do they do? In *A citizen's guide to government* (3rd ed.). Toronto: McGraw-Hill Ryerson.
 - Read pages 21–41
2. Diversity geomap dashboard. Definity Insurance Foundation and New Power Labs.

Supplementary Readings

- N/A

Assignments

- Week 1 Discussion – Learners will be asked to self-assess their participation in the Weeks 1, 2, and 3 course discussions at the end of Week 3 – this self-assessment will contribute to their self-assessed participation grade.

See the Assessment and Evaluation section of this Course Outline for details.

- **Assigned:** Assignment 1
- **Assigned:** Assignment 2

Tests/Exams

- N/A

Week 2 (January 17, 2026)

Module 2

Approaches, Theories, and Tensions

Topics

- Approaches to the study of local government (understanding the main theories)
 - Institutional theory
 - Community power theory
 - Social movement theory
 - Political economy theory
 - Public choice theory
- Key tensions in local government structure and relationships
 - Efficiency versus effectiveness
 - Municipal role
 - Autonomy
 - Interests

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, students should be able to:

- Distinguish between five groups of theories of local government
- Demonstrate an understanding of theories by applying them to a local issue
- Identify key tensions that are evident in the structure and relationships of local government in Canada and the implications for local government

Readings

Required Readings

1. Graham, K., Phillips, S., & Maslove, A. (1998). "Approaches to the study of urban governance." In *Urban governance in Canada*.
 - Read pages 19–41
2. Tindal, C. R., Tindal, S. N., Stewart, K., & Smith, P. J. (2017). *Local government in Canada* (9th ed.). Scarborough: Nelson Education.
 - Read Chapter 1 – The Promise of Local Government

Supplementary Readings

- N/A

Assignments

- Week 2 Discussion – Learners will be asked to self-assess their participation in the Weeks 1, 2, and 3 course discussions at the end of Week 3 – this self-assessment will contribute to their self-assessed participation grade.

See the Assessment and Evaluation section of this Course Outline for details.

Tests/Exams

- N/A

Week 3 (January 24, 2026)

Module 3

Development and Evolution of Local Government in Canada

Topics

- Early development
- Growth and reform
- The millennium
- Right size?
- Unorganized territories

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, students should be able to:

- Describe the early development of local government in Canada
- Explain the influence of the *Baldwin Act* on local government today
- Identify the pressures and forces that have shaped local government
- Critically compare the different municipal structures
- Reflect on ongoing pressures for change and emerging responses

Readings

Required Readings

1. Spicer, Z. (2022, May). Organizing Canadian local government. Future of Municipal Government Series, Volume 1. The School of Public Policy, University of Calgary.
2. Taylor, Z. & Dobson, A. (2020). Power and purpose: Canadian municipal law in transition. IMFG Papers on Municipal Finance and Governance, No. 47.

Read:

- Chapter 1 - Introduction, pages 5 - 11
- Chapter 2 - Defining the provincial municipal relationship, pages 11 - 15
- Chapter 6 - Asymmetrical arrangements, pages 53 - 61

Supplementary Readings

- Isin, E.F. (1995, June). Rethinking the origins of Canadian municipal government. Canadian Journal of Urban Research 4(1).
- Slack, E. & Côté, A. (2014, July). Comparative urban governance. Future of cities working paper. Foresight, Government Office for Science.
 - Chapter 1 (pages 8–9) and Chapter 2 (pages 10–24).

Assignments

- Week 3 Discussion – Learners will be asked to self-assess their participation in the Weeks 1, 2, and 3 course discussions at the end of Week 3 – this self-assessment will contribute to their self-assessed participation grade.

See the Assessment and Evaluation section of this Course Outline for details.

Tests/Exams

- N/A

Week 4 (January 31, 2026)

Module 4

Governance Machinery, Processes, and Structures

Topics

- Municipal councils
- Municipal decision-making structures
- Municipal governance processes
- Changes to the structure and machinery of municipal government

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, you should be able to:

- Explain the role of the mayor and members of council
- Distinguish between different municipal decision-making structures
- Describe the implications of municipal political parties, term limits, and different forms of election on municipal decision-making
- Explain issues of representation and decision-making

Readings

Required Readings

1. Association of Municipalities of Ontario. (n.d.). Municipal 101.
2. Moore, A. A. (2017). IMFG perspectives: The potential and consequences of municipal electoral reform. Institute on Municipal Finance and Governance
3. Sancton, A. (2021). *Canadian Local Government: An Urban Perspective, third edition*. Oxford University Press.
 - Chapter 10, pages 165 - 189
 - Chapter 12 - pages 212 - 228

4. Spicer, Z. Local government and politics in Ontario, Chapter 6, pp. 91 – 109. In *The Politics of Ontario*. Collier, C.N. & Malloy, J. (2024). Toronto: University of Toronto Press.
5. Taylor, Z. (2019). *Shaping the metropolis: Institutions and urbanization in the United States and Canada*. Montreal & Kingston: McGill-Queen's University Press.
- - Chapter 4 - Toronto - pp. 85 - 137 **OR** Chapter 6 - Vancouver - pp. 193-242.

Supplementary Readings

- Breux, S. (2024, Deember 20). What do councilors and mayors like and dislike about their job? *Canadian Municipal Barometer*.
- Bergeron, P. (2024, February 28). Quebec launches new helpline for politicians after hundreds quit office. *Global News and The Canadian Press*.
- Gragasso-Marquis, V. (2024, February 22). Gatineau mayor abruptly steps down, citing difficult climate for municipal politicians. *Global News and The Canadian Press*.
- Simmons, G. (2025, April 16). Ontario government proposes expansion of strong mayor powers to 169 more municipalities. *The Hamilton Spectator*.
- MacLeod, B. (2025, April 19). Essex County municipalities unanimous against strong-mayor powers to be enacted May 1. *Windsor Star*.

Assignments

- Friendly reminder that Assignment 1 is due at the end of next week, i.e. Friday of Week 5.
- Week 4 Discussion

Tests/Exams

- N/A

Week 5 (February 7, 2026)

Module 5

Administrative Structure, Accountability Officers, and Municipal Agencies, Boards, and Commissions

Topics

- Municipal administration models and influence
- Accountability structures and officers
- Agencies, boards, and commissions

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, you should be able to:

- Identify the different municipal administrative structures
- Assess the nature of the relationship between elected representatives and staff
- Explain municipal accountability processes and identify key accountability roles
- Identify the implications for municipal decision-making and accountability of municipal, inter-municipal, and provincially established municipal agencies, boards, and commissions

Readings

Required Readings

1. Lucas, J. (2013). *Hidden in plain view: Local agencies, boards, and commissions in Canada*. Institute on Municipal Finance and Governance, Munk School of Global Affairs, University of Toronto.
2. CAMA. (2023, March). The role and significance of the chief administrative officer position in Canadian municipal government. A CAMA “white paper” on Ontario’s strong mayor legislation and the pivotal role of the CAO in providing good governance. *Canadian Association of Municipal Administrators*.
3. Sancton, A. (2017). Accountability officers and integrity in Canadian municipal government. *Institute on Municipal Finance & Governance*, Munk School of Global Affairs, University of Toronto.

Supplementary Readings

- N/A

Assignments

- Week 5 Discussion (optional)
- **Due:** Assignment 1

Tests/Exams

- N/A

Review Week (February 14, 2026)

There are no learning sessions this week. You may use this time to review course materials.

Week 6 (February 21, 2026)

Module 6

Intergovernmental Relationships

Topics

- Relationships with provinces
- Municipal and federal relationships
- Options for new relationships
- Other options for new relationships
- Inter-municipal relationships
- Reflections on intergovernmental relations

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, students should be able to:

- Describe the evolution of municipal relationships with provinces
- Describe the formal and informal municipal relationship with the federal government
- Identify opportunities and challenges in inter-municipal relationships
- Assess pressures for change in municipally oriented intergovernmental relationships
- Describe options for change in municipal intergovernmental relationships

Readings

Required Readings

1. Eidelman, G. & Lucas, J. (2023, February 2). How do municipal mayors and councillors communicate with other levels of government? Evidence from a multi-level survey of Canadian elected officials. *Canadian Public Administration*.
2. Hachard, T. (2020, November 27). What we expect from regional and city governments is increasingly out of step with their powers. *CBC News*.
3. Gibson, R. & Dale J. (2023). Do more, with less: The realities of local government in rural Ontario. *The Canadian Geographer*, 67(1). pp. 176 – 187.
4. Flynn, A., Des Rosiers, N. & Albert, R. (2021, June 15). How to get cities out of their constitutional straitjacket. *Policy Options*.

Supplementary Readings

- Horak, M. Toronto and the GTA: Governing Ontario's Global City, pp 310 – 328. In Collier, C. & Malloy, J. (2024). *The Politics of Ontario*, second edition.
- Brennan, A. (2025, January 28). Intergovernmental relations: Perceived importance of municipal government. *Canadian Municipal Barometer*.
- Bula, F. (2025, January 4). "As provinces meddle more in municipal issues, cities raise concerns about political overreach". *The Globe and Mail*.
- Broadbent, A. (June 2, 2017). Cooperation rather than coercion: An informal approach to effective regional governance in Canada. Maytree.
- Previl, S. (2025, April 7). From tariffs to crime, where do rural communities want election action? *Global News*.

Assignments

- Week 6 Discussion

Tests/Exams

- N/A

Week 7 (February 28, 2026)

Module 7

Relationships with Indigenous Governments and Peoples

Topics

- Understanding past and current relationships

- Municipal-Indigenous governance relationships
- Paths for future relationships

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, students should be able to:

- Identify and explain the significance of key legislation that has implications for First Nations governance
- Describe the types of First Nations governance
- Assess the differences between First Nations and municipal governance
- Identify current relationship options for municipal-Indigenous relationships
- Consider the implications for municipalities of urban self-government and the duty to consult
- Reflect on opportunities for new governance relationships at the regional and multi-government level

Readings

Required Readings

1. Heritz, J. (2018, December). From self-determination to service delivery: Assessing Indigenous inclusion in municipal governance in Canada. *Canadian Public Administration*, 61(4).
2. Palmater, P. (2018). Restoring the place of Indigenous Peoples in the GTHA. Institute on Municipal Finance & Governance.

Supplementary Readings

- Vizina, Y. & Wilson, P. (2019, June). Reconciliation with Indigenous peoples: A holistic approach. Toolkit for Inclusive Municipalities in Canada. Canadian Commission for UNESCO.

Assignments

- Week 7 Discussion

Tests/Exams

- N/A

Week 8 (March 7, 2026)

Module 8

Municipal Finance

Topics

- Municipal budgets
- Revenues
- Expenditures
- Capital budgets
- Balancing the budget – case study
- Need for change

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, students should be able to:

- Explain the importance of the municipal budget and budget process
- Describe the main types of municipal operating expenditures
- Identify the main sources of municipal revenue for operating and capital budgets
- Explain the challenge of balancing a municipal budget
- Assess issues associated with key municipal revenue sources and expenditures
- Identify pressures on municipal finances and options for change

Readings

Required Readings

1. Please review pp 97 – 101 in the Week 6 reading Spicer, Z. Local government and politics in Ontario, Chapter 6. In *The Politics of Ontario*. Collier, C.N. & Malloy, J. (2024). Toronto: University of Toronto Press.
2. Miller, D. (2025). David Miller, participant in IMG at 20. Video. Watch from 1:38:42 to 1:46. Note that Miller is contributing to a celebration of the work of the Institute on Municipal Finance & Governance at the beginning and the end of his remarks – please be patient for a minute until Miller focuses on governance and finance.

3. Slack, E. (2025). Reflections on municipal finance over two decades and thoughts for the future. IMFG@20.
4. Taylor, Z. & Dobson, A. (2020). Power and purpose: Canadian municipal law in transition. *IMFG Papers on Municipal Finance and Governance*, No. 47.
 - Read Chapter 5 – Finance, pages 45 - 53

Supplementary Readings

- Kitchen, H., & Slack, E. (2016). More tax sources for Canada's largest cities: Why, what, and how? Institute on Municipal Finance and Governance. (Good summary chart on page 27.)
- Rider, D. (2018, February 17). Municipal sales tax remains cities' elusive funding solution. *The Toronto Star*.

Assignments

- Week 8 Discussion

Tests/Exams

- N/A

Week 9 (March 14, 2026)

Module 9

Policy-Making and Service Delivery

Topics

- Municipal policy-making
- Municipal service delivery
- New directions in policy and service delivery

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, students should be able to:

- Describe the municipal policy-making role and process
- Describe the range of municipal services and service delivery options
- Explain how municipal policy relates to service delivery challenges

- Contribute to a case study discussion on policy-making

Readings

Required Readings

1. Lucas, J. & Smith A. (2019, February 11). Multilevel policy from the municipal perspective: A pan-Canadian survey. *Canadian Public Administration*, pp. 270-293.
2. Eicker, U. (2021, November 26). *Opinion: Municipalities must take leadership on climate*. Concordia University.
3. Eidelman, G. (2025). *Reflections on who does what*. IMFG @ 20.
4. Johnson, N. (2023, December 04). *Uber launches lawsuit over 'bad faith' council vote, calls on court to overturn ridesharing cap*. CTV News Toronto.

Required for Case Study Discussion

Spicer, Z., Lyons, J. & Graham, K. (2020). *Local government in practice: Cases in governance, planning, and policy*. Toronto: Emond Montgomery Publications.

- Banning Plastic Bags (pages 271–275)

Supplementary Readings

- N/A

Assignments

- Week 9 Discussion

Tests/Exams

- N/A

Week 10 (March 21, 2026)

Module 10

Relationships with the Public

Topics

- Relationships with the public
- Participation and engagement
- Relationships with interest groups

- Relationships with municipal citizens
- Taxpayer-accountability relationships
- Challenges and opportunities in the municipal relationship with the public

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, students should be able to:

- Distinguish between the different types of relationships that municipalities have with the public
- Assess the influence of special interests, taxpayers, and consumers on municipal decision-making
- Identify key challenges in the relationship that municipalities have with the public and some opportunities to strengthen the relationship

Readings

Required Readings

1. Donaghy, M.M. The role of participation in global/world cities. Chapter 19, pp 286-299. Vogel, R.K. (Ed.). (2024). *Handbook of urban politics and policy*. Cheltenham, UK: Edward Elgar
2. Kopec, A. & Sheldrick, B. (2020, Summer). The adoption of open government by local governments in Canada. *Canadian Journal of Urban Research*, 29(1), pp. 70 - 93.
3. Jones, K. (2023, October). Community engagement in local communities: Hearing the voices of the public. School of Public Policy, University of Calgary. Future of Municipal Government Series, 16(32).
4. Graham, K.A.H. (2015). The paradox of participation: An overview of public participation and local government in Canada, Chapter 2. In Sancton, A. & Zhenming, C. (2014). *Citizen participation at the local level in China and Canada*. Routledge: New York.

Supplementary Readings

- Andrew-Amofah, B., Flynn, A. & Wood, P. (2022). A new agenda for local democracy: Building just, inclusive, and participatory cities. Institute on Municipal Finance & Governance and School of Cities. IMFG Papers on Municipal Finance and Governance, No. 60.

- Mertz, E. (2018, April 12). Contest seeks ideas to make Edmonton healthier in many ways. GlobalNews.ca.
- Froman, A. (2019, January). Four way to engage citizens in local government. *Municipal World*.
- Gray, J. & Mahoney, J. (July 10, 2017, revised July 11, 2017). Ontario developers form group aimed at mitigating housing reform. *The Globe and Mail*.
- Cummin, L. (July 19, 2016). The city wants to engage more youth in urban planning. *Torontoist*.

Assignments

- Week 10 Discussion (optional)
- **Due:** Assignment 2

Tests/Exams

- N/A

Week 11 (March 28, 2026)

Module 11

Looking to the Future

Topics

- Key issues
- Globalization
- Technology
- Climate change

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, students should be able to:

- Identify a range of issues facing local government
- Critically assess key issues and the implications for municipalities related to technology and globalization
- Describe how municipalities are constrained and enabled through the example of climate change

- Explain the future pressures and opportunities for local government

Readings

Required Readings

1. Tindal, C. R., Tindal, S. N., Stewart, K., & Smith, P. J. (2017). *Local government in Canada* (9th ed.). Scarborough: Nelson Education.
 - Read Chapter 12 – Future Prospects for Municipal Government.
2. FCM and Abacus Data. (2019).

Everything is local: The role of municipalities in Canadians' lives and opinions about new funding tools. *Federation of Canadian Municipalities and Abacus Data*.

3. Fenn, M. & Matheson, J. (2020). Municipal priorities for 2020 and beyond: Part one. Strategy Corp.
4. Fenn, M. & Matheson, J. (2020). Municipal priorities for 2020 and beyond: Part two. Strategy Corp.
5. Slack E. & Hachard, T. (2021, June 9). Let's empower municipalities, too often the little siblings of federalism. *Policy Options*.
6. Coates, K. (2019, September). City states and the future of Canada's smaller communities. *Municipal World*, 129(9), 11–12.
7. Meyer, S. (2025, March). Canadian municipalities continue leading the tariff fight. *Municipal World*.
8. Alberta Municipalities. (2025, February 19). Analysis: Potential impact of tariffs on municipalities.

Supplementary Readings

- N/A

Assignments

- Week 11 Discussion

Tests/Exams

- N/A

Week 12 (April 4, 2026)

Module 12

Course Review and Final Reflections

Topics

- Course review
- Reflection on key themes

Learning Objectives

- N/A

Readings

Required Readings

- N/A

Recommended Readings

- N/A

Assignments

- Week 12 Discussion – Learners will be asked to self-assess their participation at the end of this course week (Week 12). This self-assessment will contribute to their self-assessed participation grade.

See the Assessment and Evaluation section of this Course Outline for details.

Tests/Exams

- N/A

Week 13 (April 11, 2026)

Module 13

Final Thoughts

Assignments

- N/A

Tests/Exams

- Take Home Exam